

ActInf OrgStream 006.1 ~ d20 Governance: an experimental governance environment

Source: [YouTube](#) Playlist: Active Inference OrgStream Duration: 1:30:21 |

Uploaded: Unknown Transcript method: auto_caption

hello and welcome this is active inference org stream 6.1 it's January 22nd 2024 and we're here with the D20 governance team and project so I will let them all introduce themselves this should be a very fun and interactive session so thank you all for joining and looking forward to your presentation and the disc discussion cool yeah thank you Daniel um so I'm sent uh hoston uh and I am a community lead at The Meta governance project and uh one of the developers and researchers with the D20 governance project um I'm here with Asel andita um and I'll let them introduce themselves now maybe uh Hazel and then [Music] hi um thank you for coming to the live stream uh my name is Hazel I'm Affiliated I'm kind of in the mdo of community environment atmosphere um I am political theorist I'm a researcher with D20 um before I pass to Janita also want to highlight another of our team member who isn't here V is her birthday happy birthday V hi I'm Janita I'm a software developer um have been involved in the Dow ecosystem working on some projects um around uh dowas in the past and uh this project is my main um sort of uh interaction with the metago community but um I'm generally pretty interested in in all the work that they're doing and um yeah researcher and governance Etc cool um so with that we're planning to do a uh presentation today and then the presentation will also have some interactive demos uh for people who are joining us in the Stream um and yeah so with that we'll get started um I should also say before we get started that um I want to thank Daniel for inviting us to come and speak at this um I've known Daniel for as long as I've been doing the community lead work at medov and I've had a lot of uh really interesting discussions uh with him about uh uh cognitive security uh stigma G um and governance in general um un less uh familiar with the kind of uh resources is happening at the Active inference Institute um so really glad that uh Daniel and the their Community was interested in having us come and join so that we can um present our work and learn from the insights of this group of researchers so with that um let's go ahead and get into the presentation um great so uh before starting um there is this uh Discord link and actually um it's not in my clipboard

so I'm going to generate a uh going to generate a new invite um and then I'll will share it in our chat here in Zoom then Daniel can share it um in any like whatever way is applicable um and then yeah so this is going to be a uh link to our Discord server um where the bot for this project is hosted um it's the D20 governance server um and we're going to do some demos today and so if you want to participate this is the place to join for that um if you join uh come in and say hi um and uh yeah so with that um I'm going to pass it over to Hazel who's going to give us a bit of an overview for today's presentation yeah um so the flow of this presentation today will be um some demonstration of the functionalities we built sprinkled with um some conceptual thinking um so we're going to start with giving you guys a background on where this how this project came to be and we will introduce our first functionality um that's D20 AG where we're going to be interacting and we will demo the culture modules and talk a little bit about Community rule which is where and how this was inspir this project and we'll talk about two more functionalities that's value group voice actually three more and continuous input and then we'll end with um a Q&A and discussion so moving on to the next slide um a really brief overview of this project is D20 is a Discord bot that allows communities to play governance games in an AI large language model mediated environment so groups of people can come together to embark on a governance what we call governance quests and experience a diversity of governance structures decision-making processes power distributions and cultural Dynamics um through building the discore bot D20 aims to help lay the collective decision-making foundations necessary for online communities to conduct their own governance experiments do governance education do future scenario planning and make real life decisions while bonding communities through play and a sense of playfulness I'll pass it to chanita yeah um so actually sent if you don't mind going to the next slide I think there's a a little gift I wanted to reference um okay so the original inspiration for this project was a tool called Community rule which um this gift on the screen depicts Community rule is basically a templating tool that allows you to define a modu structure for your community's governance so there are four types of um modules that you may select and combine culture modules decision modules process modules and structure modules and uh Community rule basically allows you to um combine and create sort of nested hierarchies of these modules that you can then export into a template format um so our original Vision was to basically take this allow someone to export this template and then import it into our Discord bot and have it just work for um sort of uh your community's governance um but we also at the same time wanted to um kind of have this like uh notion of game play or um allow people to experiment with these

modules in a like very low stakes manner that you could then um you know move forward and and um uh take into higher Stakes situations like actually using these modules to govern your community so um the idea of low stakes is kind of where the governance game idea came from um so we started out uh you know developing um a more fully-fledged kind of game experience and we were trying to um design a a narrative that took people through a series of different uh decisions that they had to make as a community um and and we're trying to be uh pretty um honest to the original like structure of community role with respect to these four different types of modules um but some something we realized as we went along was that like game game design and like making a really kind of interesting and exciting gameplay experience is like a a hard problem in and of itself um and we were kind of trying to accomplish a lot of things at once we realized so we decided to pair back um the game structure a bit and and sort of focus it around what we call like these mini quests or experiences um where um people in the community can kind of um like still experiment but in a in a sort of like on a shorter time frame and with less narrative overhead um they can still experiment with uh these governance modules um so we'll we'll get a bit more specific about the actual structure of the game later on but that was kind of the origin story of the D20 bot um one other thing I'll mention is that um as we were like developing this and um doing play tests with different communities um we got a lot of feedback around the sort of um this llm mediated communication feature so one of our original ideas was to um Implement these like implement the idea of culture models but in a more whacky manner by um using llms to modulate um how people are communicating um so you know for example we have like an eloquence con types in the Discord is uh trans translated into Shakespearean English um and we found that like people were finding a lot of delight in these culture modules and so we started thinking more about um you know how this game can allow allow people to experiment with um communication and an llm mediated information landscape or like how um even the frustration that you experience when trying to communicate amongst uh sort of this like chaos of information can um be interesting or can can teach us something about um yeah next slide please so um actually I'm going to just go back to the other side really quick because there's something I wanted to add on to what Gober just saying there Janita um something that's also kind of interesting about uh you know modeling kind of uh communication system based around Community rule is that the the the kind of implementation of the different kinds of culture modules um can vary quite a bit so if you look at this uh actually well you can't see it because it's not on culture right now in the GIF but in

culture there's a values module and we'll talk about that a little more but one of the interesting things is that that's a quite Broad category for uh like structuring communication uh as like mediated and filtered through a language model um so some of the modules are very uh like narrowly defined and some of them are more uh abstract um another thing that's sort of interesting is the this tool was kind of originally designed to basically help communities like Define the way that their governance actually is uh rather than necessarily the way that they want it to be um it's more of a retrospective Tool uh rather than a prospective tool and part of the reason that is that it's like that is because the community rule itself is not actually programmatic in the sense that um like setting up these structures doesn't do anything um it's not connected to any apis or um the web app doesn't even do anything um other than just represent and so kind of thinking through how to translate this into a um something that's programmatic um was actually a really interesting exercise and it's it's it's worth saying that too because one of the things that kind of was also part of the the impetus for this work was some of the past uh user research that we had done um with communities who were interested in uh incorporating more governance tooling into their Suite of online tools um we uh Valen I in particular did a lot of uh user research um with Community uh participants and leaders uh while we were doing some uh work on both medo's Gateway project and also um policy kit and now Collective voice projects and one of the things that came up a lot in those conversations was the need for um some kind of uh primer or some kind of uh like accessible uh way to even develop the kind of uh governance muscles or impulses that an online community would need to um really make use of the the the tools and Community rule is actually at least in my opinion a really great tool for introducing communities to um what like a very like uh simple kind of representation for what governance uh could look like the drag and drop uh web app and the kind of um Simplicity of like seeing your structure represented even even though like you can actually get these very strange kinds of um uh like recursive uh structures like you could have values inside of a board inside of a uh values inside of a board inside of values inside of a board just kind of uh infinitely recursing um but it's a really accessible and approachable way of um actually seeing what it means to have a structure to make something that is often implicit expl um we heard that there is a lot of this need for making governance more understandable and tangible um and so that's part of the reason that we were taking Community rule as a foundation um and then we also heard that um there was this desire to have something that is more explicitly uh interactive um a lot of tooling can sometimes be set up a poll um and then let it run and um you don't really get any kind of

interactive feedback as a result of participating in that process um it can feel like a lot of online interactions where you do something maybe you see like a react number go up or down um but largely speaking you do something and you kind of don't even know if what you did had any impact and um so this idea of kind of creating uh a way of introducing people to online governance through play seemed to be something that was coming up in our research um Janita talked about this a little bit this this sort of in terms of the kind of conceptual development of the project moving from a kind of General governance Tool uh and even like a game to thinking of it more as a kind of uh surface for governance uh experiences um and I think this is maybe important to linger on just a little bit because um uh there's something about having a good experience with governance um or a meaningful experience with governance that can really change your whole relationship to why you would even care about the topic um and so uh even though like as we'll kind of get into our game is uh or our kind of governance experiences are kind of designed in some ways to kind of uh be uh induce confusion um they're also designed to kind of uh stimulate the imagination for what a kind of governance could look like um and still have some fun in the way in order to take basically translate the experience of playing into thinking about implementing uh these kinds of systems in your communities um the other thing is that for I mean one of the hard things about designing uh governance uh scenarios games environments Etc is determining what the resources are that are actually being governed at all um it's it's very nice to kind of Imagine This Very abstract uh governance uh scenario but if there are no like Stakes uh in in terms of resources then there's really it's not entirely true but it's it's much harder to kind of devise a governance interaction space and so you know I think we started and maybe we'll pick up a little bit on this in some of the kind of prompting discussion later on um but we started with this idea of kind of uh living in a kind of like post communication collapse type environment um where people for whatever reason still needed to communicate over the internet but the ability to do that had degraded so much um that uh communication itself um was this kind of or Clarity of meaning was a scarce resource of sorts um and the other thing that we were interested in was thinking about um how to how to kind of like uh produce that kind of scarcity uh or that kind of fleeting sense of meaning um and the way that we use culture modules was uh one way of kind of artificially placing people in these kind of abstract uh communication environments so um yeah I'll go to the next slide uh Janita will talk a little bit about the D20 agora mode yeah so um what you see going on here on on the right is um the D20 agora so the game is is basically broken up into two modes there's the Agora um or sorry

the bot rather um is broken up in two modes the Agora is what we're looking at it's kind of this um asynchronous environment where all of the um you know culture decision Etc modules are available to experiment with but there's no kind of active game or narrative going on that requires um people's synchronous attention um so um we we yeah we intended the Agora to be um an experimentation Zone and the jump off point for the um the actual games experiences whatever you want to call them um and and we'll talk about that second piece in a bit this is um basically just a kind of uh GIF but actually because we're doing the stream this way it's basically redundant so just going to the next slide um so we're going to go into a little bit more detail about uh the way the culture modules uh are implemented and uh uh designed um we'll start with hazel and then I'll pick up a little bit after yeah um I think culture module is one of the really interesting functionalities that we build and it's um the way through which we mediate kind of all messages and communication through the switching on and off of culture modules so to give an introduction um I think culture modul is one of our most notable features um and it works to influence the group's communication Norms with what we call um we we picked up the term culture modules from the community rule um where basically we use um large language models to modify the content and the input of users messages and temporarily place the users in the artificially constructed uh culture communication environment and a lot of these culture modules have pre-generated large languish model prompts um that the AI use to transform the text input um of the user's message on Discord and give an output and we see a lot of the Transformations happening here if you type something the you will be your language be mediated and changed by a bot and um with reference to like whatever culture model that culture module that's active um so these are the six culture modules that we've built so far um and to just yeah we have amplify we have eloquence obscurity ritual value wild card um amplify just intensifies the message sentiment like if I say that you know today is fine um it's going to amplify it to be something like today is great or today's awesome um The Best Day Ever um eloquence makes messages more um persuasive and in our uh formulation it kind of turns the message into like a Shakespearean like poetry kind of way which is really really interesting to read out loud um in the environment M and obscurity kind of makes the messages more obscure by like a scrambling of words but we actually found out like really surprisingly that it's still kind of readable if you stare at it for a little while but it just makes it a little bit harder to read um and ritual is interesting because it actually changes the meaning of your input it will align if you we turn on the ritual module um it will like align your message and to like with the previous message

that's being sent um that if the pr person say like you know I love like tea or something and you say I hate tea it would change it to like I like tea to have this like really interesting mediated uh group consensus that's very constructed um and we have values we have a list of values is defined in the oror channel you can propose revision to it and you can check values with the check values um function um and the last one is a little bit special the Wild Card module um it transforms messages into the voice um of the culture that's being defined by the previous group um so this is um like a special one we built in um it's designed to construct like a new culture module every time a group successfully completes a build a community Quest so uh the transformation prompt is constructed using the text content of the decisions made um through governance mechanisms uh made during the quest and made by the group and the questions the players are tasked with making a decision are related to the voice that's going to uh formulate and inform the what the wild wild card um culture module is and we will talk a little bit more about the build community quests later and I'll pass to send to talk a little bit about the um conceptual thinking behind using um AI generated prompts yeah um I we T I talked about it actually a little bit already um kind of maybe before it was scheduled in our presentation but I think one thing that um maybe to kind of uh come at it from a different perspective is um you know we had people at um dweb Camp uh when we did an in-person play test of this and they um when when the eloquence mode was turned on they ended up just like reading these posts out loud um and afterwards we had people sort of talking about how there was this they could imagine a scenario where um they're in a Discord or some kind of communication platform and people are basically talking past each other um they're on their own individual tracks and there's the the idea of kind of coordinating or responding to what the other person was saying is basically uh impossible um and they said it would be interesting if they had the ability to go into a kind of eloquence mode um or step into a channel um where all the communication was structured in this way and I think this kind of points to the something that I think we want to come back to in the the discussion but this kind of um question of producing artificial uh stability in the environment um and um like I think often it's maybe speaking for myself I think often when I'm posting um I become very attached to what it is that I'm posting um for a couple reasons the the content is um like I can really only express myself through text usually um and so a lot of the uh nuances uh of course of how I might actually Express something are lost in the communication platform or the medium um but also there's the kind of sense that like what I'm saying is also kind of part of a long uh archival history uh and part of the kind of reputation that I've uh either explicitly or implicitly

developed within a community whoa the chat um and uh um being able to kind of create a a situation where everyone who's posting is kind of conditioned by the same logic of communication I think uh helps to serve a coordinating function um even if it's a frustrating coordinating function um but it also serves to give a little bit of distance between what it is that you're saying and what it is that you're communicating and then how you continue to communicate as a result of those Transformations um people including myself also noticed that the way that you type changes because you're in some ways trying to kind of imagine how will your text be transformed um by the language model and I think this kind of introduction of a kind of flexibility um in this kind of artificially stable system um owes for a slightly different approach to thinking about how you make decisions with other people online um I think it it increases the kind of uh complexity uh of making decisions because the ability to accurately communicate is is made more challenging but it opens you up to um new ways of relating to your peers in that environment um and so I think one thing that we're sort of interested in is um how do these culture modules kind of influence uh the decision- making uh patterns within online communities so at this point we were planning on doing a demo um but the the Discord is already quite uh active and the culture modules have been uh pretty thoroughly engaged with um but one thing that we were interested in is sort of right now the Discord uh bot and the project is hosted on uh our Discord server um we still need to go through the process of setting it up as uh a bot that other uh Discord servers can install if there's interest the code is open source and uh you can set the environment variables and actually just uh put it in your own Discord the reason that we're I'm saying this is because like right now it's hosted here and this is a kind of decontextualized space on the internet in some ways um like people from your community are here right now and you're missing all of the context of the channels um the the kind of flare that you might have set up with your account um the ability to interface with the kind of specific environment that you uh operate in um and we're actually really curious to see what that is like because right now it feels kind of distanced and also there's no real incentive or magnetism to this particular Discord server um the only reason you would come here is to like play with this but it's not integrated into the place where you are in community with others and so to kind of stimulate or sorry stimulate that experience a little bit we thought it would be interesting to have maybe alongside the rest of the presentation um people having a conversation about something to do with active inference um we were thinking that it would be interesting to have just a kind of General um account from the active inference community of what it is that they're interested in with active

inference um and um how they understand the term and then um to maybe kind of just carry on uh attempting to have a conversation in the way that you might normally do it in your own Discord um just to kind of give a little bit of that sense of the the kind of Transformations happening in a contextually meaningful environment so um I'm not going to pause on this we'll just go to the the next slide uh and this is going to be uh Janita talking about uh one of the specific culture modules which is values um so did you intend for there to be um a few moments for discussion uh uh for discussion like in the in the Discord yeah um I was thinking I'll read a question from the chat and also we can talk a little bit about active inference or continue on but I'll read a question first upcycle Club writes can you combine two or more modules into a new fused one yeah um I think that's actually what we were experiencing a few minutes ago um so you can have any number of culture mod modules running at the same time um right now I think there aren't any culture modules running but if for example we wanted to turn on amplify as well as eloquence um anything anyone P going to be run through both of these prompts so um your the sentiment of your message will both be Amplified and transformed into Shakespeare English um one of the interesting things to point out from like a technical perspective in terms of how the code is actually implemented is there the order in which the culture modules are activated has an impact on the way that the text is transformed um it's the culture models are stored in a list and that list is being read through in order um and the Order of the list determines the the way like the the sequence of the processing so you have your input text let's say we have amplify then eloquence so your text goes to the amplify transformation and then the output of that goes to the eloquence transformation um so there's there's even kind of an ability to create uh like basically Amplified followed by eloquence and eloquence followed by amplify are two kind of different functions it and I mean that's like in a technical sense but there's another way in which in my experience anyways the the eloquence module kind of has this way of overriding more or less all the other modules um it's so distinctive in terms of the way that it's uh characterized um that I often find that if I want to get a sense of the flavor for the other modules I have to deactivate the eloquence module um there's also um you know uh I can't remember but I think in the um the Agora you're not even the the ways of changing the culture modules isn't exposed or maybe it's not exposed in the quests but to to answer to also kind of answer what I think the person in the chat might have been asking is there's no way to kind of make like to specify a module um that isn't already specified um so you're kind of you kind of have what you're given the Wild Card module changes um as a result of the quest um and um it's only temporary so um after another group

plays the quest then the Wild Card module changes um we would like to explore the idea of more or less being able to kind of specify the way in which um the large language model is transforming the text um but that uh that I think there's a lot of uh ways that the the kind of uh system was architected it was very kind of organic and not uh predetermined maybe at some point I need to be interested in talking about that but um the way that it was developed didn't kind of have the path dependencies that led us to uh a system where you could um just create your own module on the flag awesome and just one more question from Pablo FM he wrote If in our role playing game we have our set of values and our lingo and lore can it be adapted uh so one thing that we we uh I kind of mocked up a a um a very simple like web app um that would allow people to kind of basically Define their own quests um and it it never really was finished being developed but we're interested in definitely being able to let people construct their own role playing scenarios Define their values in advance um maybe even have them stored in a database every time that the the server where the bot is hosted is restarted um the all of the data is wiped because it's just stored to of the way that governance is conducted in that community so you can imagine joining a Discord server and then um in order to participate in some collection of channels um you first need to go through a governance Quest um and part of that would involve communities being able to Define their governance um in advance and the way that their Quest is structured so that when people join they have a stable reproducible experience um and this is also the the the idea of kind of working with Community rule we we explored this idea of like actually exporting the um the when you play a quest you have these different opportunities to change which culture module you're interfacing with um what decision-making method you're uh module you're using and we had this idea of kind of showing people how they how their governance uh stack or their governance structure changed over time and then allowed them to basically export the any thce of that and then use it as a way of uh generating a new Quest so these are all like kind of future development ideas um but the short answer to Pa's question is no awesome continue on this is really fun really fun definitely bringing a smile to many people and there's a lot of a lot of seeds that you planted like the contextless the decontextualized or the recontextualizing of the dialogue in a space that's new to us it's in your lobby and there's all these different formal informal structures so we'll return to some of this but let's see a little more awesome cool uh okay yes so Janita to talk about values yeah so um so another one of the culture modules we have available is called the values module um so I think Hazel or ENT have touched on this earlier in the presentation it's basically um a way that you can sort of um softly enforce the

values of uh your community so um anyone can um propose uh so there's kind of a fixed number of values that we have and anyone can propose a revision uh to um any one of these values to replace it with a new value um and then what you can do is when someone posts a message um you can see if that message is in alignment with the values that the the community have chosen by running this command called check values so um I'll just demonstrate that on um on a message so we see at the um I think someone ran the the values command so uh the community defined values we have are inclusivity collaboration Trust no respect and intentionality um so I'm going to go ahead and run check values on upcycle club's message um and the values analysis appears to be that this message does indeed align with our values and then there's a description for for why the bot thinks that it aligns with the values um uh yeah so so um just another yeah building block that we've included um to to sort of allow people to experiment with like how how things can be made more um things that are generally um implicit can be made more explicit um and uh okay yeah I guess we can try if Daniel if you want to try the proposed value revision just propose uncore value underscore revision and then it'll take you through the flow of um replacing the no respect value maybe go go through it on your side just because that's what screen's captured but this is epic it's very flexible and I'll just read one comment just while you're setting it up I'll read one comment from Dave he wrote here's a very practical application of the kind of Transformations you're demoing please consider working on this at some point glossing a discourse that's expressed in one vocabulary into a discourse expressed in a different analogous vocabulary identifying corresponding terms and Concepts in two fields or in two approaches to a given field is expensive deploying the result of such Discovery will be useful on its own and a Spur to the effort to develop more correspondences this would involve a lot of under the hood activity required by full machine translation EG German to French but could be driven by much simpler rules AKA patterns thank you Dave all right so you're typing up respect and justifying it yeah so so you'll see that um we all have the the option to object it's kind of like um a pass by default unless there are any objections to the values within a certain time period um so provided that no one yeah lazy consensus is the term for that uh decision- making process um provided that no one objects to this value it'll be it'll be added to our list cool how long is the time like you could set different amounts of time yeah I think the default is like a minute minute yeah yeah you could set the time like you could program that but uh we haven't partially because one the someone could set it for like 60 Minutes um or someone could set it for like one second I mean you could like specify the like the boundedness of what's allowed um but usually because anyone who

objects to one of these values is going to be able to pretty quickly realize they object um our sense was that you really don't need that much time for this decision yeah oh to totally makes sense it just reflects how that could be a one month review process like in a dii scientific review setting with the right interfaces or it could be really rapid like feedback from the individuals and they're time bound activity and then that feeds back into the game like new rule here's how we propose new rules or here are the options for rules or here's how we're going to apply which filter and that just adds so many plot twists even before active inference or without any kind of cognitive modeling at all or systems modeling just approaching it from the pure game play it's really fun and people in which are like yeah already pointing out a lot of ways it can be used to play if not be useful yeah one thing to point out that's kind of hidden at the moment uh is so let's go to this value analysis of upcycle Club um uh where are they so they were um aligned and if we go to their uh profile um oh okay no um there should be something that uh I saw that there was a melline tag on Friendly's profile uh yeah yeah the I don't know if it's doing it right now but um I think we might have taken it out at some point because it wasn't part of the the full feature set that we wanted to ship but um this function can assign an aligned or misaligned uh tag based on the result of the the analysis and then you could do do whatever you want with that um from a programmatic perspective one idea would be that like if uh you as a community are aligned um any user that you're aligned with um you are either not affected by the disruptions in language that are caused by the culture modules um or the effects are less intense and so there's an incentive to uh remain aligned if you want to be able to effectively coordinate with your peers so um the the demo thing the demo idea that we were going to um explore was um asking uh people in the chat to answer the question of what do you value in communication environments um perhaps from the perspective of active inference and then we can do some uh value uh analysis um you even propose new values um and we can sort of to see this kind of uh iterative feedback loop play out um so maybe we'll just leave that again like just keep playing with that in the background in the chat um feels uh you know something about just stopping and watching a chat and not saying anything feels uh too strange um so um uh yeah we'll go to the um building a community mode um I know that I'm supposed to talk about this but I feel like I've been talking for a really long time even though we like structured the speaking setup um hazel do you want to talk about this at all or do you want me to still pick it up go for it okay um yeah so uh building Community uh we have a build a community Quest um it's uh we actually explored a bunch of different quests this kind of like post communication collapse quest uh we explored one that

might still be in the repa somewhere called the Josh game um which was a uh kind of uh actually hezel do you can you talk about that just very briefly like what the Josh game was yeah um I think the Josh game is like um it's like intending to be an um a game that's placed on individual identity it's kind of inspired by I think one of us saw like a news online about the like IRL Josh game that a bunch of people are named Josh um and they kind of had like a just like a fake like noodle sword fight um for the name Josh where the last person standing who like won like via Rock Paper Caesars is the last person who's crowned Josh um and the rest of the people like lost their ability or lost their right to be Josh um and I think like through we kind of made some version of that where we all enter the game with our like Avatar and name replaced with like a random Josh it can be like josling Josh or like Josh or tree Josh or whatever else um and then we kind of like compete we kind of give SPI some um speech in this like kind of word based contest where we kind of compete to be who's the most worthy Josh or who's the last Josh um and yeah it's just like um like a playful way to experiment with who's who um how do you like what's in the name and how do you like kind of like establish or spin out like a little playful identity and we imagine like a lot of different ways we can potentially play with that um but but that's the that's the general that's the general like um playful context of the Josh game cool thank you hesel uh another funny uh thing about that game is um uh Joshua tan um uh was the executive director of medov at that time and uh is still currently at medov as a research director um and uh we actually never played this with him but it's uh his uh GitHub handle is the last Josh um and so I don't know there's something very funny about spending one's time uh making a game that like is not even directly referencing someone but is yet nevertheless connected somehow like organizationally so a little bit of you know meta for for the the stream posterity um so to to the build a community quest uh yeah 25 minute narrative bu game um and um you can prompt it in the chat um I mean you can try it uh it's been a little while since we've actually done it um the thought might break um so and also it takes a long time to do but um basically um you can set up the parameters of a quest um you can decide how many players need to join um and whether or not are generated as part of the the quest and then you go and you play it and the goal in the in the game or the quest is to basically kind of as a group collectively establish um yourself as a new group to give yourself an identity of some sorts um you you have to answer questions like what's your name uh what's the main topic of interest that your group talks about and in what way does your group can speak or communicate to each other and for each of these questions there are proposal functions um you can WR various proposals um there are voting uh

decision-making processes there are some deliberation questions that are sent um and there are also different methods for making decision um at the moment I think we've implemented uh two or three like a very small amount of decision-making methods um and then there's a a Fourth Kind of implicit feudalism uh method um which is if the Google players um are unable to make a decision after three tries the bot basically just picks a decision at random um partially because um I don't know it's it's hard to know like how deep we want want to go into the implicit feudalism thing um but basically one kind of like background thing that's also connected with all this is the idea of um thinking about the ways in which the platforms were used to communicate with each other are uh structured and Nathan schneer is written a really nice piece called um the implicit feudalism of uh social media and and it is looking at like the history of the server architecture the server client architecture um from as far back as the BBS era up to now and his argument which I won't go into a lot of detail about is basically this architecture and the ways that we communicate in general are basically uh representative of a kind of uh feudalism um it's not explicit but it's just implicit in the way that we communicate and um one of the theses is that we could give communities online a uh different ways of um governing or setting up governance systems that are not inherently feudalistic and this is kind of where the modular governance and the the metag governance angle of this project comes into play um and a lot of the the game is about kind of introducing uh people to the idea that they could change uh on the Fly how they make decisions um they can have agency over um the way um their communication happens in a way that is not uh is circumscribed by the developers of platforms and to be honest it's also circumscribed by us um it's it's very difficult to create a system that doesn't have any kind of predetermined uh structures in place um but for example in the game if if you fail to make a decision about any of these topics then you're given the ability to uh change the way you make decisions um and then if none of that works then a decision is just made for you and this is in some ways meant to kind of bring to the surface for players the ways in which um they can and cannot exercise agency um when communicating and the other thing to say about this this question why you go through this process is that um all of the answers to these questions are then uh fed into a template for an llm transformation module this is the Wild Card module and what that means is that like one thing that I think is there there are a lot of experiments with kind of uh multi-user input uh interfaces into llms but not so many um and I think one thing that's sort of interesting to think about is how can we open up um an imaginary about um I guess two things one is um having more uh Collective uh inputs into um the the kind of uh way that the large language model is

interfacing with uh our Communications um but also kind of um being clear through experience the ways in which the way that we communicate and the decisions that we make have an impact on the ways in which our environments uh change around us um so this is kind of maybe like the stigma kind of thing a little bit like you have these like uh interactions these like uh uh pheromones that people are leaving behind which are their decisions and then you kind of experience the result of that in the Agora and that also changes the way that you interact in the Agora and maybe the way that you interact in the build a community Quest um so I mentioned that if a failure if a decision fails um then you have the ability to uh change it and the way that that happens is through a kind of continuous input mechanism um there's a kind of multi-user uh input uh uh there's a way of uh inputting your uh preferences for a decision um and then once um a certain level of preference collectively has been expressed then uh a decision is made and the mechanism is triggered um it's also a display of community conviction and uh it also just kind of acknowledges the fact that there are governments failures I think one thing that kind of comes up sometimes in discourses around governance and also perceptions around governance is that governance is kind of a when we talk about it as a system um it can sometimes uh or a model it sometimes be perceived as this like static set and fix and don't think about again uh experience and sort of a lot of the literature that kind of thinks about especially the emergence of meta governance in in governance in general as a kind of development of government um is basically like hyperfocused on the ways in which failures manifest in in decision-making um so we want wanted to make sure that when this happened um there was a way of exercising agency and and kind of giving players the experience of steering or uh responding to the the environment uh another thing to maybe say just quickly about this is that this kind of uh mechanism is also one of the like most uh popular uh often cited uh kind of uh ways of uh references for this is Twitch Plays Pokemon um which is a emulator of Pokemon uh uh setup on Twitch and then some python binding so that anytime someone types uh up in the chat then uh an up uh command is uh sent to the emulator and the character moves up um and so you you could have a chat that's basically just collectively distributedly controlling the game and uh this is cool and extremely chaotic um but there are maybe like two scenarios in Twitch place Pokemon or like in Pokemon where you really have to press the same button maybe like six times in a row in order to even move to the next part of the map um and so you can't stay in the kind of pure chaos mode um or else you'll never complete the game and so the developer of the the python binding uh set up this way for people to oscillate or move between uh what was it like uh democracy and Anarchy

um and and when you're in uh Anarchy mode it's exactly like we just described it's all continuous just taking the input um and then when you're in democracy mode there's a kind of time buffer in which um all the responses are collected and whichever response gets the most input in that period of time is the response that's triggered so it sort of slows down the the reading of input um and allows for groups to coordinate and actually get past these situations uh where they couldn't otherwise and then it's super interesting project it's very old at this point as well but it's I highly Rec who are not familiar with it already to go to look at it um another great reference in this area is uh trust uh moving castles project which is also looking at Community controlled games through twitch and is uh kind of a more contemporary example um yeah so we wanted to demo this and you can see that it's already happening in the Discord chat a little bit um people are typing a culture module and then plus or minus one and then once it passes a certain threshold then uh that module is activated so we didn't have any prompt for this one uh so maybe we'll just kind of move to the next section unless you know wants to pause and discuss something since that seems to be a pattern here demo discussion I think one quick thing I would add is we told we we built the cool down time because I think when we are playing it we ourselves find ways to break it and cheat on the system um I think that's also part of the fun of building the game of thinking about not just thinking about ways that we can play but also to think about to play through the disruption by disrupting the disruption um which was really interesting which is why we built the cool down so nobody can spam and just get what they want at least not immediately yeah that's a great Point uh yeah yeah thank you um anything you want to add maybe Janita or okay so progress um we've done a playthrough of this at D camp we talked about that a little bit um we did a kind of annotated uh playthrough uh like an anotated version of that playthrough um I'm not going to show it because it's not set up um and I can't remember where the link is actually but anyways um that was a really interesting process and we should make a slide for that next time um we also did a presentation as part of a symposium in Geneva called uh the she Seashore of endless worlds um and we've also presented this at a uh one of the weekly meta governance seminars so um and now we're here um which is very exciting um and I'm really looking forward to this stream existing because I think this is uh a very fun uh engagement with the project um so yeah with that um with that maybe we would move into a little bit of discussion even though we've had this nice kind of uh interjection discussion so far um and we were thinking of um like in what ways is this kind of uh project um how does the active inference Institute Community kind of see relevance in it um I guess in terms of both maybe

setting up experiments or um kind of using it as a complement to or the subject of research and then another thing that we're interested in is kind of thinking about this kind of this thing that we alluded to earlier this kind of like uh communication collapse in like a kind of post llm or whatever uh kind of uh technology were post at this point uh communication environment where um the like there's this idea as far as we understand we're not experts in active inference that like one of the kind of reasons to study and model this um in this field is to kind of be able to uh anticipate and respond to unpredictable environments somehow like the idea of active inference and I'm curious that this is corrected is to kind of produce a kind of more stable system than uh we might um otherwise uh design and and this game in many ways kind of purposely introduces um uh instability into the communication but it's also those those those disruptions are themselves kind of metastable environment ments and so there's this kind of strange interplay between stability and instability and the ways in which this kind of experien of um expanding the kind of governance imaginary for how we might interface in a more ambiguous uh uh epistemic uh context so um we'd love to discuss that a little bit and then to maybe um leave uh everyone with some information about us um here are our names and our respective roles in the project um some of our contact information um and then some links to our projects and um we should also mention that the project was incubated and uh uh supported by the Met governance project so yeah that's our presentation thank you so much for having us and um um I'll leave the discussion prompts up and would love to see where the conversation goes awesome well thank you for presenting this like there's a lot to say a lot of places to jump in it feels so natural despite the tech in some ways being so new in practice and in our hands but even though you all have made this it feels like people just slotted into it and I think it it does touch on a lot of active inference ideas like on a more technical but also on a more informal level like just starting with the informal the idea that there's multiple agents or multiple entities with varying Blends new mixtures new filters and overlays of bodied and digital all these different modifications and and layerings and identities so this kind of like open cyber complex identity engagement space and the way that still there are these features of ecological psychology and that those fundamental features like relating to sense making on the inbound and decision selection on the outbound we can understand whether it's like leaving an emoji or the words that are produced all all of that is behavior and it's behavior um that's different but with our body so there's all these kind of like Rich Dynamics so the field provides more questions than answers on those fronts but shows like how far the Gap is between the general unified approach and how deep the last um mile is in application but this

really like connects it from what otherwise could be super abstract about like multi-agent online interactions which is like what the research papers in metov or in active inference how they'll describe it and this like really connects it and it's like in this Discord so it kind of becomes embodied in the real chat so that was one thought another thought was like it it shows that words matter and that our speech acts online matter by representing them in this kind of fun and unique way and there's other ways to to represent people's speech online like going back and curating older posts that was something we had done or seen in the metago slack and then here with some new shiny affordances from the language models and all of that um to have words that have informal import with the sentiment that we convey uh filtered or not and then also to bring in Acts that have kind of Quasi formal import like actually changing the rules of a game at some level of analysis and and being able to hold the fun and playful and comical and that whole aspect and also seeing that that's even paradoxically or not like what's important for high reliability distributed settings or for establishing trust or new ways of communicating when there's change thank you for yeah thank you for letting us speak I think to be fully transparent I think we are still very actively uh this is not a finished project and we don't uh present it as a finished project I think we're still very much in the process of imagining um use cases not just use cases but places where Um this can be immediately useful or playful or make sense right because I think today we're really fortunate to demonstrate it in a way that feels that has the split screen it demonstrate in a way that feels very calm but we've also had like playthroughs and demonstrations where when it needs to be like put into like say like 10 minutes it's really confusing it's just like a bunch of messages blowing up and everybody speaking um and I think yeah some users think it's really kind of chaotic um yeah I think um yeah I think like we yeah we we really appreciate speaking today but would really still love to hear from you guys um what are some of the use cases um and even like modules that you find that's like most accessible um or any research potential that could potentially um like be interesting stemming from this or other ways that we can I think play together like for the purpose of like governance Spirit spiritedness cool if someone writes something in the chat we can read it but just one thought that's kind of a general approach in active inference modeling which is analogous to some of the work we did like in 2022 with dii distributed science decentralized science is take a look at systems that are often engineered from the top down and then think about it from the bottom up in terms of the sensory inputs and then the capacity for Action the affordances of different agents in the system and so take that kind of view from the inside so one kind of scaffolding of an approach that is pretty General cross

active inference settings is like connect up that constraint or like the modifications that you're putting onto the environment and then interface that with schemes for the kinds of input that people receive and actions that they receive so like different actions maybe people have different roles so they can only do Emojis or people can type in chat and then different inputs people could see different channels or maybe some people are seeing it visually and some people are having it read so make a kind of scheme for who are the players and then with the players plus the board on that's kind of the board game setup and it's a different board and different players but I think even with the um title of the project you kind of allude to that role play um yeah that's really interesting um yeah the title is also kind of uh a funny one um because there are no dice involved um uh but it's it's catchy um the yeah I think having like more persistent um consequences uh is an interesting uh Avenue I mean the kind of aligned misaligned uh role tagging that that we showed is kind of pointing a little bit in that direction but um yeah like imagining like uh kind of blank server and then like the first thing you do is interact with this and everything that you learn about the server is a result of the decisions and interactions that you have um through this would be like a really interesting way of kind of producing a somewhat like Labyrinth nonstable uh constantly evolving uh environment for people to interact in um and like yeah that's a great idea um it's really interesting I mean that is newly on the table and so it's exciting to think um digital environments whether they're personalized or shared that have a defined construction to them so it's legible here's how we're modifying the incoming posts or something so there could be situations where that's exposed or like transparent or open source and then there could be other situations where for one reason or another they don't and they would be accepting the tradeoffs with or without sharing that information and it brings like new um Nuance to all the filters that we do receive information through and as that becomes more post or multi-lingual then there's a there's so many new ways that this can come into play because people are hashing these things out and they are having a a model of who's aligned and not and so making some of it visible can maybe that's a a disconcerting look in the mirror so not every representation is probably right for every setting but in like different settings there will be people who love this mod facilitator meta Governor role and you're you're producing to TOS that help bring that to the discords where people really are yeah uh there's there's two things that are interesting somehow there one is um I mean actually working with the Discord uh interfacing is and also the API is actually kind of a nightmare um like there's a there's a function that we have that um does a bunch of like text streaming so it's taking a message and then like sending a couple words chunks at a

time to kind of produce this effect that the the message is being written by some external agent um but there's a pretty aggressive rate limit on how quickly you can edit messages um in Discord um so there are some kind of like constraints there um and I think the there's um there's something about this um I think I can one thing that I can sort of see is that there this this kind of model that we're talking about of like a kind of really uh emergent and flexible and somewhat unpredictable uh structure for and and and a structure where no one person really has the same view on the system there's no uh holistic view um maybe even as an admin um then like you're opening up so many kind of unpredictable moderation questions I mean we already have enough challenges um or at least the discourse will will kind of point to the the kind of numerous moderation challenges that we have uh and kind of maintaining uh our discursive spaces aligned with some kind of sense of community value um but like the ability to kind of have uh an environment where no one has the same View kind of opens up this like huge like how do you even conceive of moderation in that way um there's there's also the like a there's also this um this problem of information overload um so we explored like having the the the Genera response um actually show you the information um like the the original input using like a spoiler tag um but it it was just too just too much like it was visually cluttered um and another thing that actually happens here is like I want to figure out how to like have it match token length so that the input and the output are kind of like correlated to each other and length right now there's this kind of uh it it will elaborate so much that it breaks the natural flow of communication um and like it introduces a kind of temporal friction and so like moderation uh to kind of expose what's happening in the background kind of naturally puts a kind of like break in some way on the kind of way in which we're communicating which could you know be beneficial or uh or not thing and then yeah like this like dystopian thing yeah I mean there are a lot of ways that this could be applied that are uh not benevolent um I very like authoritarian um in in nature so it's uh it is there is also this kind of yeah I think the yeah the moderation surface just become so difficult to figure out how you approach yeah what one interesting approach there is that now with these llms the space of moderation is in the semantic not just the syntactic so a lot of Discord Bots or trending lists or all these things are based upon the syntax of like how something is spelled or actually like how word is used with all the kind of false positives and false negatives now we're in a different space or mode of false positives and false negatives with the semantics and that's a a different and a more latent space and one that really gets at the cognitive diversity and different people's understanding of different words and decisions and events but that's kind of the real space as

well and so making the maps of that cognitive semantic territory instead of saying okay no name calling here's the list of names now that is going to be elaborated on from something and and maybe uh and also just so new Vistas for how people want to engage or not and like you brought up massive opportunities and challenges for attention and overload and just the pace of all this augmented text is extremely high and so it's very intense also though people do a lot of intense digital experiences yeah it's so true I think there's like a some relationship between the intensity of digital experience that you're uh comfortable or have previously experienced and how quickly you pick up this this spot um we've done this in some other contexts where people are just like I have no idea what is happening um and I think if you are if you tend to be like extremely online um this feels very natural um and if you're not it's it's somehow just way it it's uh it's too much um so that's also it's also interesting from a governance perspective as well it's like I mean I can't make any real extrapolations but I wonder if in terms of the kind of VI the viability of online community-based self-governance if there's a kind of correlation between the kind of like intensity uh digital experiences that that the community is uh game for and how broadly effective they will be or adaptive to online governance they will be um whereas communities that are less active or less digitally intense um would generally find online community self-governance um harder to adopt that's super interesting investing and communities that have variation amongst their participants in that as well well this is an epic part one and kind of play through I guess with this like maybe as we kind of close where do you want to go from here or what would be something cool in 2024 to get to or try um I don't know maybe we can each kind of try to give an answer to this um uh I think one thing that would be really cool is like they cleaning up the code base um so that it's like easier for other developers to to actually extend the work that we've been doing and contribute meaningfully um I and also getting this set up so that communities can actually experience it in their own uh contexts rather than just in the server so if there's anyone uh who is part of this community or who's watching who's interested in um kind of sifting through the codebase and figuring out how to contribute um that would be really cool um yeah I think that's that's kind of my thought I don't know Hazel Janita anything from you yeah I I'm on a similar page um I really think of this spot and this tool right now is like just a set of building blocks that um communities can ideally use to like configure their own experiences and so um I think um yeah I think it would be great to figure out ways to extend this to make it more accessible for for people to continue to experiment and and build upon what we've done yeah I feel like I really wish that more people watching this live stream or not will just come talk to us and say hi and tell us how we

can make this more useful or practical for you and that would make us really happy and I think another thing that um a topic that I'm really interested in is what kind of thing is Randomness in governance um how does like being random work and having a function that assigns like a random value work um I think there there are quite a bit of we build like a kind of random Overlord function um in build a in build a community Quest um but I feel like that's something I really want to explore more especially with regard to um what's the relationship between um Randomness and agency right like what's the setup that that gives user like the agency the feeling of agency of governance um that's something I'm interested in thinking through more um and hopefully with this project cool super exciting I hope people in The Institute Discord and elsewhere tune in to this kind of cool way to think about our shared services as governance Services really converting a space and taking everyone on this journey that's so in the moment that it's kind of like intense and flies right by so it's been an epic stream and maybe we can play around with it as you all continue to develop the framework so thank you all till next time yeah thank you so much for having us cool bye